

Minolta DiMage Xi

Slim body, no grip

The Minolta DiMage Xi is a slim form factor, which makes it very portable, and its square body makes it look completely different from the rest. The finish is very smooth, which may add to its allure, but gives no place for the user to get a firm grip. The camera is just 2 cm thick and weighs little over 150 grams.



It sports a 3.2 mega pixels CCD that generates 2048 x 1536 resolution images. The DiMage Xi is very thin and therefore, slight jerking is inevitable when shooting. Hence the pictures tend to turn out blurred. There is no optical zoom. However, the 4X digital zoom gives you some space to play around with the settings. The camera

runs on a customised Li-ion battery, or an AC adapter that comes along with the camera. It also has a 16 MB Secure Digital card included as the storage media, which can be upgraded, as and when required.

On the performance front, the device delivered very focused images, and also managed to reproduce colour precisely. The camera was particularly good in picking up the colours yellow and pink. It also reproduced the green liquid in the glass brilliantly. The specular effect was one of the best amongst the cameras of its class, with the reflection in liquid and metal looking very natural. It also managed to show gradation in shading very nicely, with the shadow dying out gradually. However, the quality of the image was very average when tested for the actual person reproduction. Though the image was dull, there was no colour loss, resulting in a warmer look. The camera averaged in the zoom test as it was all digital, and therefore when viewing the image at actual pixels in Photoshop, the image appears to be little pixelated. Hence, use the zoom, but don't blow up the image to print a particular portion, as the final output will not be satisfactory.

The DiMage Xi is priced at Rs 23,500, which is the right price for the quality it delivers, and its features. The camera is very portable and slim, making it a good travel companion.

+ Individualistic looks, light-weight
- Takes too long to save a picture in TIFF format

Price: Rs 23,500

Minolta DiMage Xi		B-	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Ergonomics	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Casio Exilim EX-M1

All looks, no performance

Casio Exilim EX-M1 is targeted at the class of people who strive to be noticed. It weighs only 56 gms, is just 3.9 cms thick, and undoubtedly is the wearable camera that Casio says it is. It sports a 4X digital zoom and 1600 x 1200 resolutions. This is just one of the cameras that supports a shutter speed of 1/4th to 1/8000th of a second. However, you cannot set the shutter speed manually. It runs on a special Li-ion battery, which is much thinner than the normal Li-ion batteries. The Exilim is charged using the docking station that is bundled along. The docking station can also be used to download the images to a PC, since a USB port is absent.

The Exilim EX-M1 is very thin, which makes it a bit difficult to operate. You also need a firm grip on the body when photographing, lest the images appear hazy. The quality of the images produced matched our expectations. The image was a little brighter (the fixed lens was to blame), and the keyboard text and the clock's hands were not clearly visible. This caused the image to look very flat. It was the same with the colour reproduction—the colours looked washed out due to high luminosity levels. The Exilim EX-M1 also failed to reproduce details, as the pattern on the curtain appeared very flat with foggy edges. In the RGB target test too, it failed to detect the colour green, causing it to appear very dark on the screen. However, the Exilim EX-M1 did well in the actual person test and reproduced image was of acceptable quality, assuring us that it could be used indoors in auto mode.

The Casio Exilim EX-M1 costs a cool Rs 20,995, almost Rs 4,000 more than other cameras that produce similar-quality pictures. There are other cameras in the market that sport higher specifications and boast of much better features than the Exilim EX-M1. Hence, this device is only recommended to those who have deep pockets and are looking for something radically different, even at the cost of ergonomics and zoom capabilities.



+ Slim form factor
- Mediocre performance

Price: Rs 20,995

Casio Exilim EX-M1		C+	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Ergonomics	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

